fact had territorial ambitions that included parts of India's northeast and Burma.

Patel was critical of the government's response to the invasion, seeing it as too placatory and weak. The deputy prime minister thought that Beijing would see accommodation as a sign of weakness, and that complacency and vacillation would increase the threat from China. Instead, Patel advocated "enlightened firmness, strength and a clear line of policy." He called for a threat assessment; analysis of India's existing and required defense capabilities; reconsideration of Delhi's support for Beijing at the UN; strengthening of India's northeast and of Bhutan, Nepal, and Sikkim; internal security measures in India's border states; improvement of transport and communication lines to the border; manning of key border posts; reassessment of India's Tibet presence and its position on the McMahon Line; and, finally, re-examination of India's external relations—including with the US.[172]

Despite Patel's stature, Nehru was the ultimate decisionmaker on foreign policy. Initially after the invasion, a disappointed Nehru questioned broader Chinese intentions.[173] But, as Henderson had predicted,[174] the prime minister decided to stay the course after receiving what he interpreted as a less antagonistic note from China in mid-November. The missive, coupled with a Chinese military pause at the Xinjiang-Tibet border, seemed to leave the door open for Sino-Tibetan negotiations.[175]

Nehru stressed the long-term perspective: India needed a working relationship with a Chinese communist regime that was here to stay. He believed that Beijing desired India's friendship and that Delhi should respond. This view was probably encouraged by Panikkar's report earlier that year that Mao had told him, "India and China cannot afford to have war." And the chairman's outline of the two Asian nations' similar problems would have done nothing to discourage the prime minister's mirror imaging.[176]

In a November note, Nehru also interpreted the lack of a Chinese demand for complete withdrawal of Indian interests in Tibet as significant. He reiterated that India lacked the military capacity to prevent the takeover of Tibet. Any attempt at stopping the Chinese advance would likely fail and would lead to Chinese hostility toward India and constant insecurity at India's borders. Nehru instead sought Tibetan autonomy, arguing that the